

"Reciprocity is the heartbeat of human connection." — Brené Brown

"The universe is a vast system of exchange... throbbing with reciprocity, from the planet to the rotting leaf." — Edwin Hubbel Chapin

I sometimes wonder what the distance is between an acquaintance and a close friend. In some way, it's conversations, shared experiences, and time spent together. That's what you have to *do* to know someone deeply. In some way, it's a process of exploration, and of finding, among all your acquaintances, the right person. With someone you connect with, the difficulty is not in the doing, that comes naturally.

My answer to this question, even if only in my subconsciousness, has often centered around a notion of reciprocity. Only recently have I thought about it more formally, though it rings true as age-old wisdom: If you want someone to be more open, be more open. If you want someone to be more understanding, be more understanding.

I have commonly thought of reciprocity in its sum totals, like a ledger that keeps the score. A simple example of this is the literal ledger kept for tracking payments – I'll get this meal, you get the next one. It's typically not written down nor carefully accounted for, but it's certainly there. This is a form of reciprocity, and it automatically stabilizes itself through behavior: if someone is generally paying more than you, they will pay less, so that you pay more. And you should understand their paying less as a comment on the state of the ledger, and in this way the ledger stays even.

Another way to think of the development of relationships is that of tearing down boundaries. As you become closer friends with someone and more emotionally intimate, the list of things you *can't* say or *won't* say gets shorter, and the things you feel comfortable saying expands. In this way, people come to understand you better and the scope of your relationship broadens. Just as price modulates the interaction between supply and demand, latently signaling when people want more, or have more, reciprocity modulates the desire for intimacy. It can feel awkward pushing the boundaries of a relationship, especially making that first move. Sending someone a message when you've never texted before. Inviting someone to lunch when you've really had more of an "in-class" friendship.

I find one of the most gratifying parts of getting to know someone the moments when you think "okay, well, I want to be closer friends with this person/ expand our relationship in some way. I'm going to do X thing (send a text, call, etc.), hopefully they (1) don't find it weird/too forward, and (2) hopefully they feel the same way," and then they don't find it weird and they feel the same way. It feels good because it's palpable and substantial progress towards a goal, and dopamine is mostly for the process, not the result. It also feels good because it relieves you of the anxiety of uncertainty, which is often worse, psychologically, than the certainty of something negative.

I have 3 actionable thoughts about reciprocity in my own life:

(1) As described above, I think of reciprocity in 2 different ways: ledger reciprocity, and developmental reciprocity. The difference is that the ledger is an ongoing thing that is added to and taken away from overtime, and at certain times it may be unbalanced one way or another, but the strength of the relationship serves as a guarantor of sorts for its eventual convergence. On the other hand, developmental reciprocity is more about the actual process of give-and-take, using behavior as a signaling method to develop a relationship. And so the main “difference,” as I see it, is that of timing, long-term vs short-term. That being said, I hypothesize that I have historically overestimated the actual timeframes, and perhaps the extent that these things are actually even different. In short, the ledger needs to be cleared faster than I currently do (I think that while people are *okay* with waiting, even in EV-neutral ledgers there are substantial costs to asymmetric delays where one person takes longer on average than the other) and moments of emotional vulnerability need to be accounted for faster than I currently do it (when a friend says “I love you” for the first time, in a way that’s simply being friendly and testing the waters for a closer relationship, just say it back). I tend to offset certain communication for the purpose of thinking about it more. Sometimes this is to formalize my thoughts into a longer message, or to think of the optimal way to communicate what I want to say. This works well in some ways and for certain things, but the neural pathway of seeking reciprocity may not actually support this. Reciprocity is actually very biological, and many biological processes have a timer. When training a dog, you can’t tell it to jump and give it a treat 20 minutes later. I had not until now even thought of it as a more fundamental psychosocial process, which evolved through almost swarm-like instincts present not just in humans but other social animals as a mechanism to support social groups (and maybe for this reason is even housed in a more “basic emotions” rather than “logical thought” region of the brain), but it is. And because it is, I should treat it as such, and in moments when I don’t quite know what to say, it may be better to find an immediate or at least relatively quick display of reciprocity, rather than a more detailed but delayed one.

(2) In terms of the actual process of trying to develop a relationship with someone, I am increasingly thinking some notion of “smooth velocity” is important, not just the total sum of interactions. As you may expect, a relationship engaged with intuitively doesn’t have a consistent rate of... anything. At least for me, if I’m not thinking about developing a relationship, it’ll just go as it goes. One variant of this is reaching out when they cross your mind, or a particular opportunity arises, and going little else beyond that.

This can work well for the value-extraction portion of relationships, once you're already close friends and comfortable with each other. But I think for relationships still in the works, this sort of sporadic communication just doesn't work very well if it doesn't scale. I've had friends who I have hung out with many times. But we've never had a 1-on-1 lunch. Often that'll be "intentional" in the sense that it's the optimal state; I wouldn't *want* to have a closer relationship with many of my acquaintances, and I'm happy where they are. But is it really intentional? Do I actually think about which friends I do or don't want a closer relationship with? Or it a bit thoughtless, and just done intuitively? I think it's the latter, and that works pretty well, but it's certainly not perfect. So the actionable thought is that I should be more diligent about actually *pushing* the relationships I want to push, being more vulnerable, pro-actively demonstrating my affection, etc. in order to actively move it forward in an intelligent way.

(3) The third, and probably most important, is that I should do more of my thinking when I'm actually interacting with people rather than in moments when I have no Wi-Fi. Despite the fact that I actually quite enjoy being thoughtful about my relationships, I find much of my social time is spent just gathering momentary value, not really thinking or being too pro-active. And enjoying things in the moment is nice, but obviously shortsighted. In many aspects of life, a little bit of foresight can be worth a lot of effort down the line. If I distributed the ~30 minutes I spent thinking about this and writing it down over all my interactions in the last few days, that would probably be more fruitful.